

From outstanding athlete to outstanding citizen

Is there more to being a student athlete than the classes and competition?

With meets almost every weekend from January to April, spending seven hours a day in the gym for practices and recovery, and a full-time class load it's impressive that there is any free time at all. For senior Chris Hiser there is still time in his busy schedule for one important thing—volunteer work.

“So, I'm a big believer in, you know, how you do one thing is how you do everything, and when you grow you develop in new traits or new practices,” said Hiser. “So, if you're constantly practicing as a young person to give back to your community, to you know, spend some of your energy and spend some of your time helping others, I think it'll have a lasting impact on your entire life.”

Hiser has been a member of the Tom Osborne Citizenship Team, a group to recognize student athletes who demonstrate a passion for service and community involvement, all four years he has been at UNL. To be a member of this team you must complete six or more volunteer activities in the community throughout the year. For the 2025 season, the entire Nebraska Men's Gymnastics team will be recognized for their volunteer efforts. One essential activity that led to this award was their work with Domesti-PUPS.

Domesti-PUPS is a non-profit organization based in Lincoln, Nebraska that provides therapy and service animals for people with disabilities. In preparation for their 25-year anniversary, the Husker gymnasts got together to clean up the Domesti-PUPS shop.

“At Nebraska we honor ourselves, we take pride in the idea of creating great people like inside and outside of the gym,” said Hiser. “Some universities might have the best gymnastics team possible, but Nebraska really harbors great people inside and outside the gym. So, we love community service work.”

Outside of the work with Domesti-PUPS the men's gymnastics team has also done volunteer work with a youth soccer camp, helped serve and feed the homeless at the Matt Talbot Kitchen, and adopted a family to celebrate with for Christmas through BraveBe. Adopting a family to support and celebrate with over the holidays was one of Chris's favorite opportunities.

“It was just a great opportunity for us to give back and support a family and to actually see it in person, because a lot of the times you don't also always get to see the impact that you have on your community, but to see it right in front of you and to interact with the families for a couple of weeks, it's a great time,” stated Hiser.

After becoming a Big 10 Sportsmanship Honoree, Hiser plans to continue giving back to his community with a few more events, one specifically being Dream on 3. This is another non-profit organization help through the university, focused on making sports dreams come true for kids with life-altering conditions.

“It's just really cool to see that impact and to help someone else you know,” said Hiser. “To see some joy in their life and just again, to have that amazing feeling because it's one thing to, you know, just want to see someone be happy, but it's another thing to just naturally see it flourish, if that makes sense.”